

**MOUNT KENYA UNIVERSITY
SCHOOL OF EDUCATION**

**ASSESSING TEACHERS' COMPETENCE AND ITS INFLUENCE ON THE
EFFECTIVE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE COMPETENCY-BASED
CURRICULUM IN PUBLIC PRIMARY SCHOOLS IN HABASWEIN SUB-
COUNTY, WAJIR COUNTY, KENYA**

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A Research Proposal Submitted to the School of Education in Partial Fulfilment of the
Requirements for the Award of the Degree of Master of Education (Curriculum
Studies) of Mount Kenya University

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DECLARATION

This research proposal is my original work and has not been presented for the award of a degree or for any other award in any other university.

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Supervisors' Approval

This research proposal has been submitted for examination with our approval as the university supervisors.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Name of Supervisor 1]

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Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Name of Supervisor 2]

School of Education, Mount Kenya University

DEDICATION

I dedicate this work to my family, who carried more than their share so that I could study, and to the teachers of Habaswein, who keep classrooms open in a place where that is never easy.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I thank God for life, good health and the strength to get this far. My supervisors have been patient with my drafts and honest in their comments, and this proposal is much better for it. I am grateful to the lecturers and staff of the School of Education at Mount Kenya University for what they have taught me, and to my classmates for the arguments, the encouragement and the shared deadlines. I also thank the head teachers and teachers in Habaswein who talked to me informally about their work while I was shaping this study; their stories convinced me it was worth doing. Finally, to my family: thank you for standing with me at every step.

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ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

Abbreviation	Meaning
ASAL	Arid and Semi-Arid Lands
BOM	Board of Management
CBAM	Concerns-Based Adoption Model
CBC	Competency-Based Curriculum
CBE	Competency-Based Education
CSO	Curriculum Support Officer
CVI	Content Validity Index
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
KICD	Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development
KNBS	Kenya National Bureau of Statistics
KNEC	Kenya National Examinations Council
KPSEA	Kenya Primary School Education Assessment
MKU	Mount Kenya University
MoE	Ministry of Education
NACOSTI	National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation
PCIs	Pertinent and Contemporary Issues
PCK	Pedagogical Content Knowledge
PWPER	Presidential Working Party on Education Reform
SBA	School-Based Assessment
SPSS	Statistical Package for the Social Sciences
TPD	Teacher Professional Development
TSC	Teachers Service Commission

OPERATIONAL DEFINITION OF TERMS

Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC): The curriculum introduced in Kenya from 2017 under the Basic Education Curriculum Framework, which puts the emphasis on what learners can do with what they learn rather than on how much content they can recall. The Ministry of Education now refers to it as Competency-Based Education (CBE); this study uses the two terms interchangeably.

Teacher competence: The combination of knowledge, skills and attitudes a teacher needs to deliver the CBC as intended. In this study it has two measurable parts: the teacher's knowledge and understanding of CBC, and the teacher's pedagogical competence.

Knowledge and understanding of CBC: How well a teacher grasps the philosophy, goals, core competencies, values, pertinent and contemporary issues and curriculum designs of the CBC.

Pedagogical competence: A teacher's ability to plan and deliver learner-centred lessons, assess learners formatively, keep assessment records and portfolios, and make good use of available teaching resources, including ICT.

Effective implementation of CBC: The degree to which what happens in the classroom matches what the curriculum designs intend. It is shown by learner engagement, integration of core competencies and values, continuous assessment, parental involvement and timely coverage of the curriculum designs.

Factors affecting teacher competence: Conditions in and around the school that make it easier or harder for teachers to acquire and use CBC competence. They include training, resources, workload, class size, instructional support and insecurity.

Public primary school: A government-funded school in Habaswein Sub-County offering Grades 1 to 6 under the CBC, with teachers employed by the TSC or the Board of Management.

Marginalised area: An area that, because of its remoteness, harsh climate, low population density or insecurity, receives fewer services and has poorer education indicators than the national average. Habaswein Sub-County falls into this category.

ABSTRACT

Kenya replaced its 8-4-4 system with the Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC) so that learners would leave school able to think, solve problems and apply what they know. Whether that happens depends heavily on the teacher in front of the class. National studies show that many teachers still struggle with CBC lesson planning, learner-centred methods and competency-based assessment, and the problem is likely to be worse in remote, arid areas where training reaches fewer teachers and staff turnover is high. Yet most of the evidence so far comes from Nairobi, the central highlands and western Kenya, and very little of it comes from the north-east. This study will therefore assess teachers' competence and how it influences the effective implementation of the CBC in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County. Its specific objectives are to assess teachers' knowledge and understanding of CBC principles and practice, to analyse their level of pedagogical competence in delivering the CBC, to identify the factors that affect their competence, and to establish the relationship between teacher competence and effective CBC implementation. The study draws on the Concerns-Based Adoption Model and Shulman's theory of Pedagogical Content Knowledge. A descriptive survey design using both quantitative and qualitative data will be adopted. The target population is 368 teachers and 46 head teachers in 46 public primary schools. Using Yamane's formula and proportionate stratified random sampling, 192 teachers will be selected, and 14 head teachers will be chosen purposively. Data will be gathered through a teacher questionnaire, a head teacher interview guide, a classroom observation checklist and a document analysis guide, after piloting in neighbouring Wajir South Sub-County. Quantitative data will be analysed in SPSS with descriptive statistics, Pearson's correlation and regression, while qualitative data will be analysed thematically. The findings are expected to guide the Ministry of Education, the Teachers Service Commission, teacher training institutions and school leaders in giving teachers in marginalised areas the support they need to make the CBC work.

Key words: teacher competence, Competency-Based Curriculum, pedagogical competence, curriculum implementation, marginalised areas, Habaswein

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Study

Across the world, school systems are moving away from curricula built around content coverage and exams towards curricula built around competencies: what a learner can actually do with knowledge, skills and values. The shift is driven by a simple worry. Many young people finish school able to pass tests but unable to solve real problems, work with others or keep learning on their own. Competency-based approaches try to fix this by changing what happens in the classroom. Teachers are expected to step back from lecturing, design activities in which learners do the thinking, and assess progress continuously instead of relying mainly on a final examination.

That change is much harder than it sounds, and teachers carry most of the weight. Hall and Hord (2020) point out that a curriculum reform is only as good as the way it is used in classrooms, and that teachers move through predictable stages of concern before they use an innovation with confidence. Where they are rushed through those stages, the reform tends to be adopted on paper while old habits continue in practice. Rwanda offers a clear example. It introduced a competence-based curriculum in 2015, and eight years later Nsengimana et al. (2023) found that many science teachers still held only a partial understanding of what “competence” meant and often fell back on teacher-centred methods. In Uganda, Kidega et al. (2024) found teachers in Gulu City facing classes of around 66 learners, poor facilities and very little training, all of which pushed them away from the learner-centred methods the new curriculum required.

Kenya began its own shift in 2017, when the Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD) rolled out the CBC under the Basic Education Curriculum Framework (KICD, 2017). The reform was confirmed in policy through Sessional Paper No. 1 of 2019 (Ministry of Education [MoE], 2019). It aims to produce “engaged, empowered and ethical citizens” by developing seven core competencies, among them communication and collaboration, critical thinking and problem solving, creativity and imagination, and digital literacy. The first CBC cohort sat the Kenya Primary School Education Assessment (KPSEA) in 2022, and in 2023 the Presidential Working Party on Education Reform (PWPER) recommended that the reform continue, although with fewer learning areas and, importantly, a retooling programme for teachers trained before the CBC (PWPER, 2023). The Ministry now uses the term Competency-Based Education (CBE), but the demands on teachers remain the same.

Those demands are considerable. A CBC teacher must understand the philosophy behind the reform, plan lessons around specific learning outcomes and key inquiry

questions, integrate values and pertinent and contemporary issues, use learner-centred methods, and assess learners through observation, projects, portfolios and other school-based tools (Mwang'ombe, 2021). Keter and Wabuke (2025) describe teacher preparedness as the backbone of the whole reform, and Akala (2021) calls teachers “the heartbeat” of the innovation, while noting that the early rollout was rushed and under-resourced. Studies across the country have found that teachers’ understanding is uneven. Momanyi and Rop (2019) reported that early grade teachers in Bomet East had only a vague idea of what the CBC required. In Machakos County, Mutua and Waweru (2023) linked weak implementation to a shortage of learning materials and high teacher–pupil ratios, and in Kinangop, Karua et al. (2025) found that many teachers knew the language of CBC but struggled to align their teaching approaches with it. An evaluation by the African Population and Health Research Center (APHRC, 2022) similarly found that effective, truly learner-centred lessons were far from universal.

If teachers in relatively well-served counties find the CBC difficult, the situation in the arid north-east deserves close attention. Wajir County lies in Kenya’s Arid and Semi-Arid Lands, where long distances, recurrent drought and pastoral mobility have long kept education indicators below the national average. Habaswein Sub-County, in the south-west of the county, had a population of about 174,000 at the 2019 census (Kenya National Bureau of Statistics [KNBS], 2019). Its schools serve a mix of settled and pastoralist families, many of them spread across wide, sparsely populated areas. Since 2023 the region has also dealt with the fallout of insecurity. Following al-Shabaab threats and attacks, large numbers of non-local teachers sought transfers out of Wajir, Mandera and Garissa, and the TSC had to hire teachers on contract to fill the gaps (The Star, 2024). Hussein (2023), writing about northern Kenya, found that CBC implementation there was held back by weak training, few resources and difficulties in adapting to the new teaching approaches.

Taken together, the evidence suggests that teacher competence is the hinge on which the CBC turns, and that the hinge is under particular strain in places like Habaswein. What is missing is careful, local evidence on how competent teachers there actually are, what is holding them back, and how much this matters for the way the CBC is being delivered. This study sets out to provide that evidence.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Ideally, every public primary school in Kenya should now have teachers who understand the CBC well, plan lessons around learning outcomes, use learner-centred methods and assess learners continuously, so that children leave Grade 6 with the competencies the curriculum promises. The Basic Education Curriculum Framework

(KICD, 2017) and the recommendations of the PWPER (2023) both rest on that assumption. Nearly a decade after the rollout began, the reality falls short. Studies from different parts of the country report that many teachers remain unsure of CBC requirements, find competency-based assessment confusing and continue to teach in the old, teacher-centred way (Cheruiyot, 2024; Karua et al., 2025; Mutua & Waweru, 2023). Short cascade trainings have not been enough to change classroom practice (Awiti, 2023; Kailo & Njagi, 2025).

In Habaswein Sub-County these problems are likely to be sharper. Teachers work in remote schools with few instructional materials, heavy workloads and limited access to professional development. The departure of many non-local teachers after 2023 left some schools with newly recruited or contract teachers, some of whom may have had little CBC training (The Star, 2024). Where teachers are not competent in the CBC, learners may miss out on the practical, skills-based learning the curriculum was designed to deliver, and the gap between marginalised and better-served regions is likely to widen. Despite this, almost all empirical work on teacher competence and the CBC has been carried out in Nairobi, Machakos, Meru, Bomet, Nyandarua and western Kenya. There is little empirical evidence on the level of teacher competence in Habaswein, the factors shaping it, or its relationship with CBC implementation (APHRC, 2022; Hussein, 2023). Without that evidence, support for teachers in the sub-county risks being generic and poorly targeted. This study therefore seeks to assess teachers' competence and its influence on the effective implementation of the CBC in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.

1.3 Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to assess the competence of teachers in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County, and to establish how that competence influences the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum, with a view to recommending practical ways of strengthening teachers' capacity in marginalised areas.

1.4 Research Objectives

1.4.1 General Objective

To assess teachers' competence and its influence on the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County, Kenya.

1.4.2 Specific Objectives

The study will be guided by the following specific objectives:

- i. To assess teachers' knowledge and understanding of the principles and practice of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.
- ii. To analyse the level of teachers' pedagogical competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.
- iii. To identify the factors affecting teachers' competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.
- iv. To establish the relationship between teachers' competence and the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.

1.5 Research Questions

The study will seek to answer the following questions:

- i. How well do teachers in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County understand the principles and practice of the Competency-Based Curriculum?
- ii. What is the level of teachers' pedagogical competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County?
- iii. What factors affect teachers' competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County?
- iv. What is the relationship between teachers' competence and the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County?

1.6 Research Hypothesis

The fourth objective will be tested using the following null hypothesis at the 0.05 level of significance:

H₀₁: There is no statistically significant relationship between teachers' competence and the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.

1.7 Justification of the Study

Three things make this study timely. First, the CBC has now reached a stage where the first cohorts have moved through primary and into junior school, and the PWPER (2023) has called for teachers to be retooled. Deciding who needs what kind of retooling

requires evidence about where teachers actually stand, especially in regions that are usually left out of national samples. Second, the north-east has gone through an unusual staffing upheaval since 2023, with many experienced non-local teachers leaving and new or contract teachers taking their place (The Star, 2024). This has almost certainly changed the competence profile of the teaching force in ways that existing studies have not captured. Third, the few studies from northern Kenya (Hussein, 2023) are small and descriptive, and none has tested the relationship between teacher competence and implementation outcomes in Habaswein. A focused study in the sub-county will fill that gap and give policy makers something more concrete than general statements about “challenges in marginalised areas”.

1.8 Significance of the Study

The findings are expected to be useful to several groups:

- **The Ministry of Education and the TSC** may use the findings to design retooling and in-service programmes suited to teachers in arid and remote areas, and to plan staffing and incentives for hardship areas.
- **The Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development** may use them to refine curriculum support materials and training content so that they respond to the realities of low-resource schools.
- **Teacher training institutions** may draw on the findings to strengthen pre-service and in-service programmes, especially in learner-centred pedagogy and competency-based assessment.
- **Head teachers and Boards of Management** may use them to plan school-based professional development, peer support and instructional supervision.
- **Teachers** may gain a clearer picture of their own strengths and gaps and of the kinds of support that make a difference.
- **Researchers and scholars** will find evidence from a region that is rarely studied, together with a basis for further research on curriculum reform in marginalised settings.

1.9 Limitations of the Study

Some teachers may be reluctant to report gaps in their own competence, fearing that the information could be used against them. To reduce this, the questionnaire will be anonymous, respondents will be assured that the study has no link to TSC appraisal, and self-reports will be cross-checked through classroom observation and document analysis. The size of the sub-county, poor roads and insecurity in some areas may make it hard to reach remote schools. The researcher will work with the Sub-County Director

of Education and local administration to plan safe travel and will schedule visits during the dry season where possible. Pastoralist mobility may also affect school attendance on observation days; observations will be rescheduled where a class is too depleted to reflect normal teaching.

1.10 Delimitations of the Study

The study will be confined to public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County. Private schools, pre-primary centres and junior schools are excluded, since their staffing and management conditions differ. The study will focus on teachers handling Grades 1 to 6 and on head teachers. Teacher competence will be limited to two dimensions, knowledge and understanding of the CBC and pedagogical competence, while effective implementation will be judged by classroom-level indicators. Data will be collected between March and April 2027.

1.11 Assumptions of the Study

The study assumes that respondents will answer honestly and to the best of their knowledge; that the records held by the Sub-County Director of Education accurately reflect the number of schools and teachers; that the schools sampled will be accessible and safe during data collection; and that the lessons observed will be typical of the way teachers normally teach.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews what is already known about teacher competence and the implementation of competency-based curricula. It begins with the two theories that guide the study, then reviews empirical studies under each of the four objectives. The chapter closes with the conceptual framework, a critique of the literature and a summary of the research gaps the study seeks to fill.

2.2 Theoretical Review

2.2.1 Concerns-Based Adoption Model

The Concerns-Based Adoption Model (CBAM) grew out of work at the University of Texas in the 1970s and is set out most fully by Hall and Hord (2020). Its starting point is that change is a process, not an event, and that it is individuals, not institutions, who change first. The model has three diagnostic tools. The *Stages of Concern* describe how a teacher's worries shift as they meet an innovation: from awareness and a need for information, through personal concerns ("What does this mean for me?") and management concerns ("How do I find the time and materials?"), to concerns about the impact on learners and about working with colleagues to improve it. The *Levels of Use* describe what teachers actually do, from non-use and mechanical use to routine and refined use. *Innovation Configurations* describe the different forms an innovation can take once it is in classrooms, some faithful to the original design and some not.

The model fits this study well. The CBC is an innovation that teachers in Habaswein are at various stages of adopting. A teacher who has only been told about the CBC in a short workshop is likely to be stuck at the level of personal or management concerns, and to use the curriculum mechanically. CBAM therefore helps explain why knowledge and understanding of the CBC (Objective 1) matters: without it, teachers cannot move beyond early concerns. It also explains why contextual factors such as training, resources and support from head teachers (Objective 3) shape competence, since each of these either answers or aggravates teachers' concerns. Critics note that CBAM focuses heavily on the individual teacher and less on wider structural issues such as policy shifts or insecurity (Hall & Hord, 2020). This study responds to that weakness by explicitly including contextual factors in its framework.

2.2.2 Theory of Pedagogical Content Knowledge

Shulman (1986) argued that good teaching needs more than knowing a subject and more than knowing general teaching methods. It needs a special blend of the two, which he

called pedagogical content knowledge (PCK): knowing how to represent a particular topic so that particular learners can understand it, which examples and activities work, and where learners are likely to go wrong. Shulman's idea later gave rise to wider frameworks, including technological pedagogical content knowledge, which adds the skilled use of technology.

PCK is relevant to the CBC because the curriculum changes not only what is taught but how it is taught and assessed. A teacher may know the content of a learning area yet lack the pedagogical knowledge to turn that content into an inquiry-based activity, a project or an authentic assessment task. The theory therefore underpins Objective 2, which examines pedagogical competence, and Objective 4, which links competence to implementation: the stronger a teacher's PCK, the more likely the classroom will look like what the curriculum designers intended. One limitation of the theory is that PCK is hard to observe directly, and self-reports tend to overstate it. For that reason, this study will combine questionnaires with classroom observation and a review of lesson plans and assessment records.

2.3 Empirical Review

2.3.1 Teachers' Knowledge and Understanding of the Competency-Based Curriculum

A teacher cannot implement what they do not understand, and the literature suggests that understanding of the CBC is patchy. In Rwanda, Nsengimana et al. (2023) interviewed twelve science teachers in three secondary schools, eight years after the country adopted its competence-based curriculum. Most could describe the rationale for the reform in general terms, but their grasp of what a "competence" is, and how it differs from knowledge, was shallow. The study was qualitative and small, but its message is important: time alone does not produce understanding.

In Kenya, Momanyi and Rop (2019) surveyed early grade teachers in Bomet East Sub-County using Stufflebeam's CIPP evaluation model and found that most had only a vague understanding of CBC concepts, which in turn hampered implementation. Mwang'ombe (2021) reached a similar conclusion in a wider review, noting that many teachers could name the core competencies but found it hard to explain how to develop them in a lesson. More recently, Karua et al. (2025) studied teacher preparedness in public primary schools in Kinangop Sub-County and found that, while awareness of the tenets of the CBC had improved, teachers' ability to align their teaching and learning approaches with those tenets lagged behind. Keter and Wabuke (2025), working with junior school teachers in Bomet County, found that preparedness, including knowledge of CBC requirements, was closely linked to how well the curriculum was implemented.

What these studies share is a gap between knowing about the CBC and understanding it well enough to use it. They were, however, conducted in regions with relatively good access to training and support. None looked at teachers in the arid north-east, where many teachers are newly recruited, on contract or trained before the CBC. This study will measure knowledge and understanding in that setting.

2.3.2 Teachers' Pedagogical Competence in Implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum

Pedagogical competence is where understanding either turns into practice or does not. APHRC (2022) observed CBC lessons in several Kenyan counties and found that while some teachers ran genuinely engaging, learner-centred lessons, many others still relied on chalk-and-talk and whole-class recitation. The difference between effective and less effective lessons lay less in resources than in the teacher's ability to plan activities, ask open questions and involve learners.

Assessment is a recurring weak spot. Cheruiyot (2024), drawing on observation and a review of earlier studies of junior schools, found that many teachers were unsure how to carry out formative and school-based assessment and kept learner portfolios mainly because they were required to, not because they used them to guide teaching. Awiti (2023) studied public primary schools in Nairobi City and found that teachers' competence in using learner-centred approaches and in assessment strongly affected implementation, but that large classes made individual assessment very hard. Murithi and Yoo (2021) surveyed 351 teachers and found that although teachers were positive about using ICT in the CBC, inadequate facilities and limited technical skill kept actual use low.

The Ugandan experience points the same way. Kidega et al. (2024) found that teachers in Gulu City often reverted to lecturing because they had not been trained in the new methods and had very large classes. Overall, the literature suggests that pedagogical competence, especially in learner-centred methods and assessment, is the area where teachers most need support. Most of these studies relied on questionnaires alone, however, and few combined self-report with observation. This study will use both, in a setting where no such evidence exists.

2.3.3 Factors Affecting Teachers' Competence in Implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum

Training is the factor most often cited. Kailo and Njagi (2025) examined in-service training in public primary schools in Kilifi County and found that the quality of training resources and materials had a significant influence on how well teachers implemented the CBC. Short cascade workshops, where a few teachers are trained and expected to

pass knowledge on, were widely seen as inadequate. International evidence supports this: professional development changes practice when it is sustained, practical and linked to teachers' own classrooms, rather than delivered as a one-off event (Darling-Hammond et al., 2017; Guskey, 2002).

Resources and workload come a close second. Mogere (2022) found that teacher preparedness and the availability of teaching materials were the strongest determinants of CBC implementation in Nairobi County. Mutua and Waweru (2023) reported that a shortage of learning materials and high teacher–pupil ratios were the main constraints in Machakos. Akala (2021) argues that the CBC was rolled out before schools had the human and material resources it needed, leaving teachers to fill the gap with improvisation.

Context matters too. Hussein (2023) studied CBC implementation in northern Kenya with 45 primary school teachers and 15 head teachers and found that teachers struggled with the new subject divisions, teaching strategies and assessment techniques, problems made worse by limited training and few materials. The staffing crisis in the north-east since 2023 has added another layer. When many experienced non-local teachers left following insecurity, schools in Wajir, Mandera and Garissa lost much of the CBC knowledge they had built up, and the TSC turned to contract teachers to keep classes running (The Star, 2024). None of the existing studies has examined how insecurity and staff turnover affect teacher competence in the CBC. This study will explore these factors alongside the more familiar ones of training, resources, workload and instructional support.

2.3.4 Teachers' Competence and Effective Implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum

Several studies have tried to measure the link between teacher competence and implementation directly. Mutua and Waweru (2023) studied 79 public primary schools in Machakos County and found that teachers' competence, measured through their knowledge, skills and attitudes, was associated with the extent to which the CBC was implemented. Keter and Wabuke (2025) used a descriptive survey with questionnaires, interviews and observation checklists in Bomet County and found a positive relationship between teacher preparedness and CBC implementation in junior schools. Awiti (2023) similarly found that teacher-related factors, including training and pedagogical skill, explained a large part of the variation in implementation in Nairobi.

The pattern is consistent: where teachers are more competent, implementation is stronger. But the studies come almost entirely from counties with better infrastructure, higher population density and more stable staffing than Habaswein. It is not safe to

assume that the same relationship holds, or holds with the same strength, in a setting where resources are scarcer and turnover higher. Resource shortages may be so severe that even competent teachers cannot implement the CBC well, or competence may matter even more because teachers have fewer materials to fall back on. Testing the relationship in Habaswein will therefore add something new to the literature.

2.4 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework in Figure 2.1 shows how the study variables are expected to relate. The independent variable is teacher competence, measured through two dimensions: knowledge and understanding of the CBC, and pedagogical competence. The dependent variable is the effective implementation of the CBC, shown through learner engagement, integration of core competencies and values, continuous assessment, parental involvement and timely coverage of the curriculum designs. Factors affecting teacher competence, such as training, resources, workload and class size, instructional support and insecurity, are treated as intervening variables. They shape how competent teachers become and can also strengthen or weaken the effect of competence on implementation.

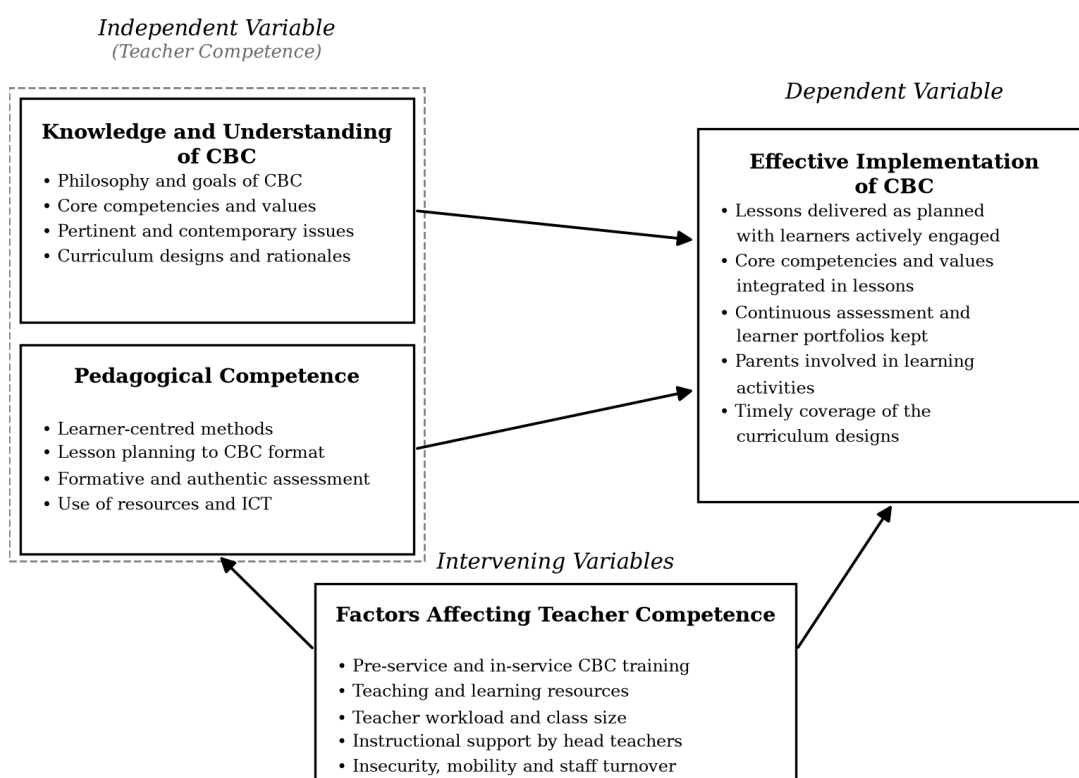


Figure 2.1: Conceptual Framework

Source: Researcher (2026)

2.5 Critique of Existing Literature

The literature reviewed agrees that teacher competence matters, but it has four weaknesses. First, it is geographically narrow. Most Kenyan studies were done in Nairobi, Machakos, Bomet, Nyandarua, Kilifi and other counties with relatively good access to training and supervision. The arid north-east appears mainly in commentary and in small descriptive studies such as Hussein (2023). Second, many studies rely heavily on teachers' own reports. Self-assessment tends to overstate competence, and only a few studies (APHRC, 2022; Keter & Wabuke, 2025) combined questionnaires with classroom observation. Third, some studies measure "preparedness" or "training" as though they were the same as competence, when a teacher can attend training and still lack the skills to use what was taught. Fourth, most studies predate the staffing disruption in the north-east after 2023 and the policy shift that followed the PWPER report, so they cannot tell us how these recent changes have affected teachers. This study responds by focusing on Habaswein, measuring competence directly in two dimensions, triangulating self-report with observation and document analysis, and including insecurity and staff turnover among the factors examined.

2.6 Summary of Literature and Research Gaps

The review shows that teachers' understanding of the CBC is often superficial, that pedagogical competence, especially in learner-centred methods and assessment, is uneven, that training, resources, workload and context shape competence, and that more competent teachers tend to implement the CBC more effectively. Table 2.1 summarises the key studies and the gaps they leave.

Table 2.1: Summary of Research Gaps

Author(s) and Year	Focus of Study	Key Findings	Research Gap
Momanyi and Rop (2019)	Teacher preparedness for CBC, Bomet East	Teachers' knowledge of CBC was vague and hindered implementation	Early grades only; conducted in a high-potential area
Mutua and Waweru (2023)	Teacher competence and CBC implementation, Machakos	Competence linked to implementation; materials and class size major constraints	Setting differs from arid, insecure north-east
Hussein (2023)	Challenges of CBC in northern Kenya	Weak training, few resources and difficulty with new methods	Small sample; descriptive; relationship not tested

Author(s) and Year	Focus of Study	Key Findings	Research Gap
Cheruiyot (2024)	Challenges of CBC in junior schools	Inadequate training; teachers unsure of assessment	Qualitative; junior schools; not region-specific
Kidega et al. (2024)	Teacher challenges with CBC in Gulu, Uganda	Large classes and poor training pushed teachers back to lecturing	Different country and level
Karua et al. (2025)	Teacher preparedness, Kinangop	Awareness improved but pedagogy not aligned to CBC	Relatively well-resourced area
Keter and Wabuke (2025)	Preparedness and CBC implementation, Bomet JSS	Positive relationship between preparedness and implementation	Junior schools; not marginalised setting
Kailo and Njagi (2025)	In-service training and CBC, Kilifi	Training materials significantly influenced implementation	Training only; other factors not examined

Source: Researcher (2026)

Taken together, these gaps point to the need for a study that measures teacher competence directly, in a marginalised and insecure setting, and tests its relationship with CBC implementation. This study on Habaswein Sub-County is designed to meet that need.

CHAPTER THREE

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter explains how the study will be carried out. It covers the research design, the location of the study, the target population, sampling techniques and sample size, research instruments, pilot testing, validity and reliability, data collection procedures, data analysis and ethical considerations.

3.2 Research Design

The study will adopt a descriptive survey design using a mixed methods approach. A descriptive survey allows the researcher to collect information from a fairly large group of respondents at one point in time and to describe the situation as it is, without manipulating any variables (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). This suits a study that wants to establish the current level of teacher competence and how it relates to CBC implementation. Quantitative data from teacher questionnaires will be used to measure competence and implementation and to test the relationship between them. Qualitative data from head teacher interviews, classroom observation and document analysis will add depth and help explain the numbers. The two strands will be collected at the same time and brought together at the interpretation stage, following a convergent approach (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). Mugenda and Mugenda (2003) note that this kind of design is widely used in educational research in Kenya because it gives both breadth and a close-up view of practice.

3.3 Location of the Study

The study will be carried out in Habaswein Sub-County, one of the sub-counties of Wajir County in north-eastern Kenya. The sub-county lies in the south-west of the county along the Garissa–Wajir road, with Habaswein town as its administrative centre. It had a population of about 174,000 people at the 2019 census (KNBS, 2019). The area is hot and dry, and most households depend on livestock, with a growing number settled around trading centres. Schools range from fairly large institutions in Habaswein town to small, remote schools serving pastoralist communities.

Habaswein was chosen for three reasons. First, it represents the kind of marginalised setting that is under-represented in CBC research. Second, it was directly affected by the exodus of non-local teachers after 2023 (The Star, 2024), which makes questions about teacher competence particularly pressing. Third, the researcher is familiar with the area and its schools, which will make access easier and help in interpreting the findings in context.

3.4 Target Population

The target population will consist of all teachers and head teachers in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County. Working figures show about 46 public primary schools with an estimated 368 teachers and 46 head teachers. These figures will be confirmed with the Office of the Sub-County Director of Education before sampling. For sampling purposes, schools are grouped into three strata that reflect the main settings in the sub-county: schools in Habaswein town and its environs, schools in rural settled areas, and remote schools serving mainly pastoralist communities. Table 3.1 shows the distribution.

Table 3.1: Target Population

Stratum	Number of Schools	Number of Teachers	Number of Head Teachers
Habaswein town and environs	10	124	10
Rural settled schools	20	164	20
Remote / pastoralist schools	16	80	16
Total	46	368	46

Source: Working estimates, to be confirmed with the Sub-County Director of Education, Habaswein (2026)

3.5 Sampling Techniques and Sample Size

3.5.1 Sampling Techniques

Proportionate stratified random sampling will be used to select teachers. Stratification ensures that teachers from town, rural and remote schools are all represented in proportion to their numbers, which matters because working conditions differ sharply between these settings. Within each stratum, teachers will be listed by school and selected using simple random sampling from a table of random numbers. Head teachers will be selected through stratified purposive sampling: within each stratum the researcher will choose head teachers of schools that differ in size and staffing, so that the interviews capture a range of experiences. The 14 schools whose head teachers are interviewed will also be the sites for classroom observation and document analysis.

3.5.2 Sample Size

The sample size for teachers was calculated using Yamane's (1967) formula at a 95% confidence level and a 5% margin of error:

$$n = N / (1 + N(e)^2)$$

where n is the sample size, N is the target population of teachers (368) and e is the margin of error (0.05). Substituting:

$$n = 368 / (1 + 368 \times 0.0025) = 368 / 1.92 = 191.7 \approx 192 \text{ teachers}$$

The 192 teachers will be distributed across the strata in proportion to their size, as shown in Table 3.2. For head teachers, the study will select 14, which is about 30% of the 46 head teachers and within the range of 10% to 30% that Mugenda and Mugenda (2003) consider adequate for descriptive studies.

Table 3.2: Sample Size Distribution of Teachers

Stratum	Number of Teachers	Proportion	Sample Size
Habaswein town and environs	124	0.337	65
Rural settled schools	164	0.446	86
Remote / pastoralist schools	80	0.217	41
Total	368	1.000	192

Source: Researcher (2026)

Table 3.3: Summary of Sample Size

Category	Target Population	Sample Size	Sampling Technique
Teachers	368	192	Proportionate stratified random
Head teachers	46	14	Stratified purposive
Total	414	206	

Source: Researcher (2026)

In addition, 28 lessons (two in each of the 14 schools) will be observed, and lesson plans, schemes of work, learner portfolios and assessment records will be reviewed in the same schools.

3.6 Research Instruments

Four instruments will be used, so that findings from one source can be checked against another.

Teacher questionnaire. A structured questionnaire will be given to the 192 teachers. It has six sections: background information; knowledge and understanding of CBC; pedagogical competence; factors affecting competence; implementation of CBC; and an open section for suggestions. Most items use a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). The questionnaire is written in English, the language of instruction for teachers, and should take about 25 minutes.

Interview guide for head teachers. A semi-structured interview guide will be used with the 14 head teachers. It covers how teachers were prepared for the CBC, the

support available in the school, the main difficulties teachers face and the head teacher's view of how well the CBC is being implemented. Each interview is expected to take 30 to 45 minutes.

Classroom observation checklist. The researcher will observe 28 lessons using a checklist based on the CBC lesson structure. It records whether the lesson has clear learning outcomes and key inquiry questions, how learners are involved, whether core competencies, values and pertinent and contemporary issues are integrated, how assessment is done, and how resources are used. Each item is rated on a three-point scale (not observed, partly observed, fully observed).

Document analysis guide. Schemes of work, lesson plans, learner portfolios, assessment records and records of in-service training will be reviewed to confirm what teachers report and what is observed in class.

Table 3.4: Operationalisation of Study Variables

Variable	Type	Indicators	Measurement	Tool
Knowledge and understanding of CBC	Independent	Philosophy and goals; core competencies and values; PCIs; curriculum designs	Five-point Likert scale	Questionnaire; interview
Pedagogical competence	Independent	Learner-centred methods; lesson planning; formative assessment; use of resources and ICT	Five-point Likert scale; three-point observation scale	Questionnaire; observation; documents
Factors affecting competence	Intervening	Training; resources; workload and class size; instructional support; insecurity and turnover	Five-point Likert scale; themes	Questionnaire; interview
Effective implementation of CBC	Dependent	Learner engagement; integration of competencies and values; continuous assessment; parental involvement; curriculum coverage	Five-point Likert scale; three-point observation scale	Questionnaire; observation; documents

Source: Researcher (2026)

3.7 Pilot Testing

Before the main study, the instruments will be tried out in public primary schools in Wajir South Sub-County, which borders Habaswein and shares similar conditions but will not be part of the main sample. The pilot will involve 19 teachers, about 10% of the teacher sample, and two head teachers, in line with the guidance of Mugenda and

Mugenda (2003). It will also include two lesson observations. The pilot will show which questions are unclear, how long the questionnaire takes, whether the observation checklist is practical and whether the scales are reliable. Instruments will be revised on the basis of the results.

3.7.1 Validity of Research Instruments

Validity refers to how far an instrument measures what it is meant to measure (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). To establish content validity, each item will be mapped to a study objective and to the conceptual framework. The university supervisors and two experts in curriculum studies will then review the instruments and rate how relevant each item is. A Content Validity Index (CVI) will be calculated from their ratings, and a value of 0.80 or above will be taken as acceptable. The pilot study will help confirm face validity by showing whether teachers read the items the way they were intended.

3.7.2 Reliability of Research Instruments

Reliability is the degree to which an instrument gives consistent results under similar conditions (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). Cronbach's alpha will be calculated from the pilot data for each Likert scale in the questionnaire. A coefficient of 0.70 or above will be accepted, and items that pull a scale below this level will be revised or dropped. For the observation checklist, the researcher and a trained research assistant will observe the two pilot lessons independently and compare their ratings to check agreement. For the qualitative data, trustworthiness will be supported by triangulating sources, keeping detailed field notes, recording interviews where consent is given, and keeping a clear record of analytical decisions (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

3.8 Data Collection Procedures

After the proposal is approved, the researcher will obtain an introduction letter from Mount Kenya University, ethical clearance from the university's ethics review committee and a research permit from the National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation (NACOSTI). Permission will then be sought from the Wajir County Director of Education, the TSC Sub-County Director and the Sub-County Director of Education in Habaswein, as well as the local administration. Head teachers of sampled schools will be contacted in advance to agree on visit dates.

Three research assistants who are familiar with the area will be recruited and given two days of training on the instruments, sampling procedures and research ethics. Questionnaires will be administered in person and collected on the same day wherever possible, to keep the response rate high. The researcher will personally conduct all head teacher interviews and classroom observations, with a research assistant co-observing

some lessons to check consistency. Documents will be reviewed on the day of the school visit. Data collection is planned for March and April 2027, and travel to remote schools will be arranged in consultation with local security officers.

3.9 Data Analysis and Presentation

Completed questionnaires will be checked for completeness, coded and entered into the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) version 29. Descriptive statistics (frequencies, percentages, means and standard deviations) will be used to address Objectives 1, 2 and 3. Mean scores will be interpreted on the five-point scale, so that a mean of 4.0 or above indicates high competence, 3.0 to 3.9 moderate competence and below 3.0 low competence. For Objective 4, Pearson's product-moment correlation will show the strength and direction of the relationship between teacher competence and CBC implementation. Simple linear regression will then be used to test the null hypothesis:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X + \varepsilon$$

where Y is effective CBC implementation, β_0 is the constant, β_1 is the coefficient of teacher competence, X is the composite teacher competence score and ε is the error term. To see how much each dimension of competence contributes on its own, a multiple regression model will also be fitted:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_1 + \beta_2 X_2 + \varepsilon$$

where X_1 is knowledge and understanding of the CBC and X_2 is pedagogical competence. Before running the regressions, the assumptions of normality, linearity, homoscedasticity and absence of multicollinearity will be checked. The null hypothesis will be rejected if the p-value is less than 0.05.

Qualitative data from interviews, observation notes and documents will be transcribed, read several times and analysed thematically following the six phases described by Braun and Clarke (2022): familiarisation, coding, generating themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and writing up. Observation checklist ratings will be summarised as frequencies and percentages. Quantitative findings will be presented in tables and charts, and qualitative findings as themes supported by short quotations. The two sets of findings will then be compared and discussed together. Table 3.5 summarises the analysis plan.

Table 3.5: Summary of Data Analysis by Objective

Objective	Data Source	Method of Analysis
1. Knowledge and understanding of CBC	Questionnaire; interviews	Frequencies, percentages, means, standard deviations; thematic analysis
2. Pedagogical competence	Questionnaire; observation; documents	Frequencies, percentages, means, standard deviations; thematic analysis
3. Factors affecting competence	Questionnaire; interviews	Frequencies, percentages, means; thematic analysis
4. Relationship between competence and implementation	Questionnaire; observation	Pearson's correlation; simple and multiple linear regression

Source: Researcher (2026)

3.10 Ethical Considerations

The study will follow accepted ethical standards for research with human participants. Approval will be obtained from the Mount Kenya University ethics review committee and a research permit from NACOSTI before any data are collected. Taking part will be voluntary. Each respondent will have the purpose of the study, what taking part involves and any possible risks explained to them before being asked to sign a consent form, and anyone may skip a question or withdraw at any time without consequence. Questionnaires will not carry names, and schools will be identified by codes in the report. Respondents will be assured that the study is independent of the TSC and that nothing they say will be used for appraisal or disciplinary purposes. Classroom observations will be arranged in advance with the teacher's agreement, and the researcher will avoid disrupting lessons. Interviews will be recorded only with permission. Data will be stored on a password-protected computer, paper forms kept in a locked cabinet, and all raw data destroyed five years after the study ends. The researcher will also respect local customs, including arranging visits around prayer times and working with local leaders. All sources used will be properly acknowledged, and the findings will be shared with the Sub-County Director of Education and participating schools.

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APPENDICES

Appendix I: Letter of Introduction

[Student Name]

Mount Kenya University, School of Education

P.O. Box 342-01000, Thika

Dear Respondent,

RE: REQUEST TO PARTICIPATE IN A RESEARCH STUDY

I am a postgraduate student at Mount Kenya University, School of Education, pursuing a Master of Education degree. I am carrying out a study entitled “Assessing Teachers’ Competence and its Influence on the Effective Implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in Public Primary Schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County, Kenya” in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the degree.

Your school has been selected to take part in this study. I kindly request you to spare some time to respond to the questionnaire or interview. There are no right or wrong answers; I am interested in your honest views and experience. The information you provide will be treated with strict confidentiality and used only for academic purposes. This study is independent of the TSC and will not be used for appraisal. Your name will not appear anywhere in the report.

Thank you for your time and cooperation.

Yours faithfully,

[Student Name]

Reg. No. [Registration Number]

Appendix II: Informed Consent Form

I have been informed of the purpose of this study, what taking part involves, and my right to decline to answer any question or to withdraw at any time without any consequence. I understand that my responses will be kept confidential and used only for academic purposes, and that the study is not linked to TSC appraisal. I therefore voluntarily agree to take part in this study.

Signature of respondent: _____ Date: _____

Signature of researcher: _____ Date: _____

Appendix III: Questionnaire for Teachers

Instructions: Please tick (✓) the appropriate box or write your answer in the space provided. Do not write your name or the name of your school on this questionnaire.

Section A: Background Information

1. Gender: Male [] Female []
2. Age (years): Below 30 [] 30–39 [] 40–49 [] 50 and above []
3. Highest professional qualification: P1 Certificate [] Diploma [] Degree [] Postgraduate []
4. Teaching experience (years): Below 3 [] 3–5 [] 6–10 [] Above 10 []
5. Terms of service: TSC permanent [] TSC contract [] BOM []
6. Grades you currently teach: Grades 1–3 [] Grades 4–6 [] Both []
7. Number of CBC trainings attended: None [] 1 [] 2–3 [] 4 or more []
8. Location of your school: Habaswein town [] Rural settled [] Remote / pastoralist []
9. Approximate number of learners in your largest class: Below 40 [] 40–60 [] 61–80 [] Above 80 []

Section B: Knowledge and Understanding of the CBC

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
10	I understand the vision and mission of the Competency-Based Curriculum.					
11	I can explain the difference between the CBC and the 8-4-4 curriculum.					
12	I can name and explain the seven core competencies of the CBC.					
13	I understand how to integrate values into my lessons.					
14	I understand how to integrate pertinent and contemporary issues into my lessons.					
15	I understand how to use the curriculum designs for the learning areas I teach.					
16	I understand the role of parents in the CBC.					

Section C: Pedagogical Competence

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
17	I prepare lesson plans with clear specific learning outcomes and key inquiry questions.					
18	I use learner-centred methods such as group work, projects and discussion in most lessons.					
19	I give learners opportunities to apply what they learn to real-life situations.					
20	I use a variety of formative assessment methods (observation, oral questions, projects, portfolios).					
21	I keep up-to-date assessment records and learner portfolios.					
22	I use feedback from assessment to adjust my teaching.					
23	I improvise teaching and learning resources from the local environment.					
24	I use ICT devices in teaching where they are available.					

Section D: Factors Affecting Teacher Competence

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
25	The CBC training I have received was adequate for my needs.					
26	I have regular opportunities for CBC professional development.					
27	My school has adequate textbooks and teaching materials for the CBC.					
28	My teaching workload allows me enough time to plan CBC lessons.					
29	Large class sizes make it difficult to use learner-centred methods and assessment.					
30	The head teacher and curriculum support officers support me in implementing the CBC.					
31	Insecurity in the area affects teaching and learning in my school.					
32	The departure of teachers from my school has affected CBC implementation.					
33	Pastoralist mobility and learner absenteeism make continuous assessment difficult.					

Section E: Implementation of the CBC

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
34	Learners in my classes actively take part in learning activities.					
35	Core competencies and values are integrated in the lessons I teach.					
36	I carry out continuous assessment as required by the CBC.					
37	Learners complete projects and practical activities as required.					
38	Parents are involved in their children's learning activities.					
39	I cover the curriculum designs within the planned time.					
40	Overall, the CBC is being implemented effectively in my school.					

Section F: General Comments

41. What would most help you to implement the CBC more effectively in your school?

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.....

.....

Thank you for your participation.

Appendix IV: Interview Guide for Head Teachers

Introduction: The researcher will introduce themselves, explain the purpose of the study, assure the head teacher of confidentiality, and seek consent to take notes and record the interview.

1. How long have you been head teacher in this school, and how many teachers do you have? How many are on contract or BOM terms?
2. How were teachers in this school prepared for the CBC? What training have they received, and how useful was it?
3. How would you describe your teachers' understanding of the CBC? Where are the main gaps?

4. How confident are your teachers in lesson planning, learner-centred methods and competency-based assessment?
5. What support do you, the curriculum support officers and the TSC give teachers in implementing the CBC?
6. What challenges affect your teachers' competence? How have resources, workload, class size, insecurity and staff turnover affected the school?
7. In your view, how well is the CBC being implemented in this school? Can you give an example of good practice, and of where things fall short?
8. Do you see a difference in how the CBC is implemented by teachers with more training or experience compared with others?
9. What should the Ministry of Education, the TSC and KICD do to strengthen teachers' competence in areas like Habaswein?

Appendix V: Classroom Observation Checklist

School code: _____ Grade: _____ Learning area: _____ Date: _____
 Number of learners present: _____

Key: 0 = Not observed; 1 = Partly observed; 2 = Fully observed

No.	Aspect Observed	0	1	2	Remarks
1	Lesson plan has specific learning outcomes and key inquiry questions				
2	Lesson introduction links to learners' prior knowledge and experience				
3	Learner-centred activities (group work, discussion, practical tasks) are used				
4	Most learners actively take part in the lesson				
5	At least one core competency is deliberately developed				
6	Values and/or pertinent and contemporary issues are integrated				
7	Teaching and learning resources, including improvised ones, are used				
8	ICT is used where available				
9	Formative assessment is carried out during the lesson				
10	Teacher gives learners feedback on their work				
11	Lesson concludes with reflection or a link to real life				

No.	Aspect Observed	0	1	2	Remarks
12	Learners are given a community service or home-based activity involving parents				

Appendix VI: Document Analysis Guide

Document	Available (Yes/No)	Up to Date (Yes/No)	Remarks on Quality
Schemes of work based on curriculum designs			
Lesson plans			
Learner portfolios			
Formative / school-based assessment records			
Records of CBC training and professional development			
Inventory of CBC textbooks and teaching materials			
Records of instructional supervision by head teacher / CSO			
Teacher staffing records (including transfers since 2023)			

Appendix VII: Work Plan

Activity	Timeline
Development and approval of the research proposal	October – December 2026
Proposal defence and corrections	January 2027
Ethical clearance and NACOSTI research permit	February 2027
Pilot testing and refinement of instruments	February 2027
Field data collection	March – April 2027
Data analysis and interpretation	May 2027
Thesis writing and submission to supervisors	June – July 2027
Thesis defence, corrections and final submission	August 2027

Appendix VIII: Research Budget

Budget Item	Estimated Cost (KES)
Literature and reference materials	10,000
Printing and photocopying of instruments	12,000
Training and remuneration of 3 research assistants	36,000
Transport and security arrangements within Habaswein Sub-County	45,000

Budget Item	Estimated Cost (KES)
Accommodation and subsistence during fieldwork	30,000
Pilot study in Wajir South Sub-County	12,000
Communication and airtime	5,000
Data analysis software and services	15,000
Ethical review and NACOSTI permit fees	6,000
Thesis printing, binding and dissemination	12,000
Subtotal	183,000
Contingency (10%)	18,300
Total	201,300